

The Tower of Arrogance

—“Alright, children, ready for another story?”

Where is Āzar? She looks around but she is not there. And she’s usually always the first to come. Abrangih, she often comes late, but even she is here! But not her sister!?

—“Wait, Varaz, wait! Āzar is not here yet!”

She runs out to go look for her. Could she be in her room? No, probably she is still playing in the courtyard, the one with the little pond. And she forgot all about Varaz’s promise to tell them another story today. Aha, there she is! Sitting on a bench.

—“Come, Āzar, Varaz is going to start! I think it’s going to be a story about the Princess. It’s gonna be so good,” the Princess and her Knight, those are Āzar’s favorites—and hers too. But then she notices that her little sister is crying, “Āzar, what’s wrong?”

Between sobs:

—“Shirowe!”

Of course! Why does he always has to pick on his little sister?

—“What did he do?”

—“He says that I am stupid for wanting to listen to Varaz’s stories. He says...,” she has to pause to gasp for some air, “... he says that those stories, it’s all lies. And only stupid kids believe in them. And that I am stupid.”

Ooh, that stupid boy!

—“Yeah, if they are so stupid, why is he then always listening in. I saw him standing in the doorway. Besides, Āzar, these are made-up stories. Everyone knows that.”

—“The Princess ...,” she looks at her with her big, coal-black eyes, tears again welling up, “she is ... not real?”

Oops, she shouldn’t have said that.

—“No, of course, she is real. Varaz told us,” she whispers, not really knowing why, “I think he has met her but he doesn’t want to tell us.”

—“Really?”

—“But shh, it’s a secret. Don’t tell anyone!”

—“Okay.”

She wipes of her nose with her sleeve and gets up.

—“Come, Borān, let’s go listen!”

They run back quickly. And sure enough, stupid Shirowe is already standing at the door. When they go past him, he makes this sudden move as if to grab them, so they both let out a little shriek and run inside quickly. —“Aha, good! Girls, you were about to miss a most thrilling story.”

For it is getting late. And the sun is almost disappearing behind the mountains, when our valiant Knight hears two people argue. He stops his horse and looks around. Where is that sound coming from? He peers into the twilight, left, right, behind. Nope! Nowhere!

~“Princess, do you hear that? Two people arguing? But there is no one here. Could it be...that they are invisible?”

The Princess laughs and replies

~“No, silly, those are the Ancient Twins!”

~“What? Where are they then?” She points...—he pauses a little before pointing to the ceiling, making them all look up—the Knight is as puzzled as you guys. But when he looks up too, he sees two old men on a ... flying carpet. 🐉

—“Pff, you’re making that up, Varaz! Carpets don’t fly.”

—“Oh, but this one does, Shirowe.”

For this is the carpet that belonged to great Solomon, King of the Jews. And it sailed through the air so quickly that he breakfasted at Tisfon and supped in Hamadān.¹ And now, before the Knight’s very eyes, the carpet is floating in the air, and on top, he sees the figures of two old men.

~“These are Them? The Ancient Twins? Princess, are they not your ancestors?”

~“They are everyone’s ancestors, noble Knight!”

~“Huh?”

~“Well, you’ll see. For they always like to tell their story. And then you’ll get it.”

~“What are their names?”

~“Nuh [Noah] and Jam [Jamshid].”

~“But if they are twins. How can you tell them apart?”

~“Well, you have to wait until they speak.”

~“Huh?”

¹Bet Ha-Midrash, V.22.

~“You’ll hear!,” and the Princess now turns to the two twins who are still bickering, “O Ancient Ones, *drōd* [hello]. You honor us greatly with your visit.”

~“*Drōd*, noble Princess...,”

“... valiant Knight, greetings.”

Thus they greet our fearless duo. ♣

To make the high, nasal sound of the first one, he has to pinch his nose, and then, to imitate the second twin, he puffs up his neck and makes a deep breathy sound.

—“See, children. That’s how you can tell them apart.”

They all laugh. But he realizes that he now has a performance on his hands: to play the role of the two twins. The things a storyteller has to do to please his audience, ha, ha.

—“Who are they, Varaz?”

—“Well, let’s have them tell us themselves.”

As they lower their magic carpet, they speak in duos on
~“Perhaps, brother, it might be impolite...,”

“... to not introduce ourselves.”

~“*Drōd* [Hello], noble Knight, I am Nuh...,”

“... and Jam, I am.”

~“And we are the first...,”

“... after the Great Deluge.”

The Knight bows reverently in front of the two twins.

~“O Ancient Ones, what deluge is it that you talk about?”

~“When men became arrogant...,”

“... scorning the Gods of the Heavens and the Sky.”

~“And they went on to do their own business...,”

“...forgetting the Gods of the Heavens and the Sky.”

~“But that greatly angered...,”

“... the Gods of the Heavens and the Sky.”

~“And they...,”

“... The Gods of the Heavens and the Sky,”

~“Vociferated...,”

“...and promulgated,”

~“Exclaimed...,”

“...and proclaimed,”

~“Thus henceforth...,”

“...to bring forth,”

~“A flood of waters on
the earth, so that what is on the earth shall die all²...,”

“...and upon the material
world the evil winters in deadly frost will fall.³”

~“And they sent a big storm...,”

“...pouring rain and snow on the world.”

~“From *Nogroz* until *Mehregān* it rained...,”

“...and from *Mehregān* to the next *Nogroz*, it snowed.”

~“And half
the world was drowned in the rain’s high waters...,”

²Genesis, 17.

³Vendidad, II.22

"...and the other half covered in snow's icy frost."
 ~"But they took mercy upon us..."
 "...the Gods of the Heavens and the Sky."
 ~"On Us, lofty Nuh..."
 "...and shining Jam."
 ~"For, every day, we payed our homage..."
 "...to the Gods of the Heavens and the Sky."
 ~"And every night, we prayed piously..."
 "...to the Gods of the Heavens and the Sky."
 ~"And so they spoke to us..."
 "...the Gods of the Heavens and the Sky."
 ~"Loyal Nuh, heed Our words..."
 "...and listen to Our commands, loyal Jam."
 ~"We want you to build an ark on the waters..."
 "...and a large *Vara* [enclosure] in the ground."
 ~"And in it, you shall gather..."
 "...one pair of each animal."
 ~"One male..."
 "...and one female."
 ~"Two of every kind in the ark⁴..."

⁴Genesis, 19.

"...two of every kind, to be kept in the *Vara*.⁵"
 ~"So that the innocent will not have perished..."
 "...but the wicked will be punished."
 ~"And so I, Nuh, built the ark..."
 "...and I, Jam, dug the *Vara*."
 ~"So, that when stormy rain came..."
 "...and thick snow fell."
 ~"When
 for seven days and seven nights storm raged⁶..."
 "...and for six days and seven nights wind blew.⁷"
 ~"No innocent was punished..."
 "...and all the wicked perished."
 ~"And when the waters receded..."
 "...and the snow melted."
 ~"We returned to a new world..."
 "...cleansed of all sin."
 ~"And all again worshiped..."
 "...the Gods of the Heavens and the Sky."
 ~"And *Bābel* [Babylon] was saved..."
 "...until their came another evil!"

⁵Vendidad, II.28.

⁶Atra-Hasis III.iv.24.

⁷Gilgamesh XI.127.

The Princess gasps.

~“Oh, no, Ancient ones. What has happened?”

~“A great evil has risen in *Bābel*...,”

“...sky high it has risen.”

~“And we have come to you, dear Princess...,”

“...with our plea to save the world once more.”

~“Tell me, what great evil?”

~“It is evil Queen Shamiram [Semiramis]...,”

“...who will be the demise of all mankind!”

Oh, no! Not her again! That evil Queen has come up with another plan. And this one, it could very well be the ruin of all men. ♣

—“What did she do, Varaz?”

—“A feat unparalleled, an endeavor so bold even the Gods of the Heavens and the Sky are frightened!”

—“What? What is she going to do?”

So far, it was really funny, with Varaz doing the silly voices. But now it's getting a little scary, so she pulls Āzar a little closer.

—“Let's listen, shall we.”

THe Ancient Twins Nuh and Jam explain

~“She has built in *Bābel*...,”

“...in ancient *Bābel*,”

~“A tower so high...,”

“...to reach the sky.”

~“To extinguish the Sun Herself...,”

“... to vanquish MEHR Himself.”

~“And not even the ire...,”

“... of the Gods of the Heavens and the Sky.”

~“Can drown it in rain...,”

“... or cover its flanks with snow.”

~“For the tower is so high...,”

“... that it even surpasses the clouds.”

~“So, we plea with you to save the day...,”

“... lest everlasting night would sway.”

Our heroes turn to each other.

~“My Knight, evil Shamiram is going to take out the Sun.”

~“And slay MEHR, my Princess. We cannot have that happen.”

~“We shall forthwith go to *Bābel*...”

~“And stop evil Shamiram,” and then the Knight snickers, “But perhaps, although it is addictive, we shouldn’t finish each other’s sentences, ha, ha.” And so, they climb upon the magic carpet of Solomon, and by lunch they are in Hamadān and just in time for supper, they arrive in *Bābel*. 🐉

He looks around to see whether they are still following. And also to anticipate the *Bāmbishn*’s interruption, he explains

—“You see, children, this was long ago, when the capital was in the city of *Bābel*. It is not so far from here really, but most of it is now under water.”

—“Oh no, the evil queen Shamiram did that?”

—“Ha, ha, no I don’t think so. That was all the Tigris river...”

—“Euphrates!”

As usual, the *Bāmbishn* would correct his every mistake.

—“Oh, right, with all those floods, I got my rivers mixed up, ha, ha. Anyway, in those days, *Bābel* was the greatest city man had ever built.”

BUT when the Princess and her Knight arrive, they see not just houses and palaces, and markets and squares, but in the midst of all that, a gigantic tower is sticking out. It is so high that you can't see the top. As the Twins had said, it disappears in the clouds. And around it spirals an enormous staircase filled with workmen, building her tower ever higher and higher.

~"Princess, how is she able to do all this?"

~"With her magic she has compelled all the people of *Bābel* to work for her. See, up the stairs, she has sent masons and stonecutters, carpenters and lumberjacks, builders and engineers, and even cobblers!" And they can hear evil Shamiram sing.

*When all are one, and one is all
To be a rock and not to roll
I am buying, a stairway to heaven.⁸*

That, children, is what evil Shamiram is up to! ♣

—"Pfwah, cobblers. Why would she need those?"

—"Well, Shirowe,..."

THE stairway to heaven is so long and high that the worker's boots, from going up and down, need constant repair. And so, that's what the cobblers are doing! But there is more. ~"Look, Princess, those gardens. They are hanging." Yes, children, the Hanging Gardens of *Bābel*. It is a true feat of Shamiram's magic. ♣

—"What are they hanging from, Varaz?"

—"Just from the air, Borān. Floating upside down. With all the plants and bushes hanging upside down. And so, if you want to pluck a rose, you just jump up and reach," pretending to jump up and grab a rose, "and ...ow, ow ow!"

—"What, Varaz? Did you hurt yourself?"

—"Ow, I forgot about the thorns!"

They all burst out in laughter. Varaz is the best!

—"But they have to stop evil Shamiram, Varaz! She is going to take MEHR!"

—"Yes, indeed."

⁸Led Zeppelin, *Stairway to Heaven*.

Look, with her magic, she has jets of water spiral upwards, twisting as if through screws, making the water from the Euphrates continually being conducted up.⁹ And with that water, she plans to extinguish the Sun. The Princess and her Knight, they need a plan. And what better way to come up with a plan than through a cup of wine, to keep the fluids in the brain flowing. 🍷

—“But as the poet says:

*For story to unfold,
by teller's own accord,
lest empty words are told,
he heeds his proper word.*

And so, we must do so too.”

He pours himself a bit of wine in his cup and takes a sip, making the children chuckle.

—“Now, where were we? Oh yes, it is all flowing back to me, ha, ha.”

THE Knight exclaims:

~“Princess, we have to stop the workers from building the tower even higher! Can we not use an antidote from the *Silver Book of Cantations*?” 🍷

—“Remember that book, children?”

—“Oh, right, the book from the Princess’s grandmama! With all the counterspells. Yay!”

—“But alas, Borān, it might not solve their problem.”

THE Princess explains.

~“Sure, we could conjure a counterspell to release the people from her spell. But her magic is very potent, and she will just cast another spell, and then they will start working again. And soon we will run out of antidote. I don’t think my grandmama’s book is going to help us now, my dear Prince.”

~“But what then? Perhaps we can grab the workers and carry them away on the magic carpet to a distant place.”

~“Have you seen how many workers there are? We would need a really big carpet...” 🍷

⁹Strabo, *Geografika*, XVI.1.5.

—“Children, where would they find such a carpet?”

—“Ooh, I know, Varaz! The carpet that daddy made for mommy Shirin! The one in the *aywān* [hall].”

—“And for mommy Mariam, Āzar! He also made it for mommy Mariam!”

Apparently the rivalry between the two queens is fought by proxy through their daughters, ha, ha. But regardless for whom *Shāhān-Shāh* Husrow made this carpet, it is huge! At least fifteen fathom [89ft] either way. With beautiful scenes of gardens and hunts. And the edges look like cultivated lands planted with spring vegetables, made of silk on stalks of gold. And their blossoms are of gold and silver.¹⁰ It’s still a mystery to him how weavers were ever able to make it that big.

—“Well, beautiful as it may be—as your mommies—, it is no magical carpet.”

And besides, those tenthousand of tenthousand of workers on Shamiram’s tower, they never going to fit. No, they need a better plan. But they think and think. And . . .

He sticks his finger in the air as if he has an idea!

—“Yeah, What, Varaz? What are they going to do?”

But then shakes his head.

—“Nope,” he slumps back down and makes his face contort, “I am afraid, children. . .”

They’re out of ideas.

~“My love, I think we should go to sleep.”

~“But we haven’t come up with a plan yet, my Princess. How can we sleep knowing that tomorrow the Sun may no longer shine?”

~“That’s why we need to go to sleep.”

~“Okay, my love, now I am confused.”

~“For a plan might come to us in our drea. . .,” she jumps up from her cushion, “what did you just say?”

~“That I didn’t get your plan to get a plan?”

~“No, that’s not what you said.”

~“Well, that I am confused. And now even more so.”

¹⁰Tabari, 2452.

~“That’s it, my sweet Knight! Confusion!”

~“And you keep adding to it, my sweeter Princess!”

~“We need to sow confusion among the workers, my sweetest Knight, so that the stonecutter no longer understands the mason, and the lumberjack not the carpenter, and the builder not the engineer.”

~“How are we going to do that, my love?”

~“Grandmama’s book is going to come to our rescue after all! For in the *Silver Book of Cantations* there is a potent spell we need and it is called Mytholinguisticissimus.” 🐉

—“Can you guys say that?”

They all try but it mostly sounds like a lot of sissies, so they laugh.

—“But what does the ... misi...sisimus spell do, Varaz?”

—“Exactly that!”

—“Huh?”

—“Remember, it is meant to confuse?”

THE Princess explains.

~“Whenever the Mytholinguisticissimus is cast upon a soul, that person no longer remembers his mother’s tongue. And he starts to speak in strange tongues. And so, when the mason tells the stonecutter to ‘Scratch off that stone’, the stonecutter replies ‘Wha? Fetch you a bone?’ And when the carpenter asks the lumberjack ‘Cut off that wood’, the lumberjack replies ‘Wha? Put on my hood?’ And when the engineer tells the builder ‘Go ahead and hang it just this tall’, the builder exclaims ‘Why should I bang my head against the wall?’ And the cobbler, he just goes cobbly-gobbly-goo.”

~“I see, they would all be yelling at each other, but no one would know anymore what to do.”

~“And best thing of all. They cannot warn evil Shamiram!”

~“But, Princess, is she not eventually going to figure it out and undo that... that misi...sisimus spell with one of her counterspells?”

~“That’s just it, my noble Knight, it’s against the Law!”

~“Law? There are laws about magic?”

~“They are laws about everything. Otherwise, the world would just unravel. And this one is by one of the greatest

wizards who ever lived, here in this very city, *Bābel*. And his name was Hammurabi and he wrote this great Law Code! Justice Herself gave it to him. For he writes"

*If a man weaves a spell
and put a ban upon another man,
and has not justified himself,
he that wove the spell upon him
shall be put to death.*¹¹

~"Alright, I see. But that's a little vague, isn't it? Let's hope, being a witch, Shamiram is not going to get off on a technicality!"

~"Well, the great Wizard Hammurabi wrote many laws, but the one we need is the law called Thermos Dynamikos Paragraph Two."

~"And what does this Thermos Dynamikos law then say?"

~"It's Paragraph Two we need! Well, it's easiest if I just show you." 🍷

—"Ready, children, for a demonstration?"

Ooh, he is going to show them some magic?! How cool is that!

—"See this cup of wine? Āzar dear, fetch me that inkwell over there. But careful, *doshag* [dear], you don't want to spill it on that beautiful dress of yours," the girl, carrying it with two hands, slowly brings the vial to him, adding to the suspense, "and now, Āzar, I want you to pour a few drops in the cup. Can you guys see what happened?"

—"Yeah, you ruined a good cup of wine."

Ha, ha, her brother sometimes could be funny too.

—"Ha, ha, exactly, Shirowe! But watch, let me swirl it? What now?"

—"You ruined it even more?"

—"Ha, ha, yes I did."

—"Look, it got all purple!"

—"Well, that's true, Āzar, but that's just it. From red it became purple, but ..."

Let the Princess explain it once more for us.

~"See, Knight of my Day, this cup of wine in which I

¹¹Code of Hammurabi, §1.

poured a drop of ink, no matter how much I swirl it again, no matter what curse I throw upon it, no matter what spell I weave, never will I be able to separate out the ink again. Let me show you,” and in a loud commanding voice, she casts this powerful spell, “Splittus Uppus!!! See, nothing! Once chaos has been created, chaos will endure.”

~“I see, so that’s the Law Thermos Dynamikos.”

~“Paragraph Two! Thermos Dynamikos Paragraph Two! And so, evil Shamiram will never be able to revert them to their mother tongue!”

~“And so, this potion, that ‘misisisimus’ thingy...,”

~“Mytholinguisticissimus!”

~“Yeah, that one, how are we going to give it to the workers?”

~“Oh, simple: the water. Evil Shamiram has made it stream upwards with her evil magic. So, the potion, we will just pour it in the water, and the workers will get thirsty and drink from the water. And thus shall we confuse their language, so that they will not understand one another’s speech.¹²”

~“A brilliant plan, as usual, Princess of the Night.” And so they confound the workers and the tower is no longer built! 🍷

—“Yay!”

He jumps up, forgetting he’s holding the cup in his hand, and spills some wine onto his boots.

—“*Āy wāy*, now the cobbler will not understand me when I ask him to clean my boots, ha, ha. But what I was going to say. As brilliant as a plan may be—and as nice as my leather boots used to be,” he pulls a sad face that makes the girls giggle, “... someone always has to mess with it!”

FOr among the workers, there is one man, an adept of the medicinal sciences, one Goropius Becanus. And he thinks to himself

~“I like the tongue of my mother. It kind of rolls of your tongue, ha, ha. And so, I am not going to drink from this poisoned water. Let others be confounded by Mytholinguisticissimus, I will retain the purity of my ancestors.” And

¹²Genesis, XI.7.

so, when the learned Goropius Becanus sees what the potion is doing to his coworkers, that they no longer know that *Aak* means good, and that *Kaa* is its opposite,¹³ he quickly runs to queen Shamiram and warns her of the mayhem the Princess and the Knight have caused. And evil queen Shamiram thinks to herself

~“You know, my tower almost reaches the Heavens and the Sky. If I conjure the magic carpet of the Ancestral Twins, I can use it to fly up and grab the Sun.” But the Knight has seen what the witch queen is up to.

~“Princess, she is going to fly to MEHR and extinguish the Light that shines on us! We have to do something!” But it is too late! Launching herself from the top of her tower, up evil Shamiram flies, higher and higher. But then something strange happens... ♪

The mandatory pause until one of them caves. This time it is one of the boys.

—“Varaz, what? What’s happening?”

THE Knight points to the witch’s neck.

~“Look, Princess, the golden chain around her neck. It is melting!” For if you fly too close to the sun, things start to melt. Just ask poor Ikaros, ha, ha. ♪

—“Who is he, Varaz?”

—“Oh, well, that’s a story for some other time. But let’s catch our evil witch queen, shall we.”

AS the chain around her neck is melting, what she doesn’t realize is that her magical pearl necklace is about to fall off. And without it, she won’t be able to conjure water upwards, or fly a magic carpet. And thus, the Invincible Sun takes His revenge. And evil Shamiram, she tumbles down the stairs, all the way to the bottom of her Tower of Arrogance. Wooh, that must have hurt! ♪

They all laugh and clap.

—“She deserves it, Varaz. MEHR’s justice is done! Yay!”

¹³Goropius Becanus, Hermathena 32.

And the Princess and the Knight, rush towards where she fell. Now, without her magic, they can catch her and lock her up for ever! And so, when she tries to run away, the river, it is blocking her. I think, children, this time, she has no escape... But, oh, no. No, no, no! ❧

He mock-shakes his head. Another thing you learn quickly as a storyteller: as their heroes, villains have to live on, lest the fount of adventures will dry up.

—“What, Varaz, what?”

That evil doctor Goropius Becanus, remember him. He still speaks her tongue, and he tells her about ... the secret tunnel underneath the river. And before the Princess and the Knight can catch her, she escapes underneath the raging waters.

~“My Princess, we cannot cross these raging waters, they will sweep us away.”

~“And even worse, my Knight, look, she has found the pearls that have fallen from her necklace. And now she has her magic back.”

~“*Āy wāy*, we haven’t seen the end of her yet, haven’t we? But, my Princess, we saved the day.”

~“Literally, ha, ha.” ❧

—“And that’s why the sun still shines, outside. Although, children, I think it is about to set down and I don’t know about you, but my stomach starts to grumble, ha, ha.”

—“How convenient, an escape tunnel. Pff. You’re always making these things up, Varaz!”

Of course, it’s his detractor who has to have the last word.

—“What can I tell you, Shirowe? This is what happened in the tale of the Tower of Arrogance. For of this tale, I am not its inventor, but merely its presenter.”

To his surprise, the *Bāmbishn* adds:

—“After having diverted the river’s flow, queen Shamiram—historical Sammu-ramat, Monarch of the Universe, Monarch of Assyria, Daughter-in-Law of Shalmaneser, King of the Four Regions of the World¹⁴—has a

¹⁴Sammu-ramat, obelisk.

corridor dug into the dry riverbed, covered by a vault with walls twenty bricks in thickness, and twelve feet high, beside and above the arches, and the breadth is fifteen feet.¹⁵ And everything, she seals off with *naft* [bitumen]. Thus, after water's flow is restored, creating a tunnel underneath the Euphrates."

Pargast, would you know about that! It seems fantasy always contains a bit of reality. Makes you wonder whether the converse is also true, ha, ha.

¹⁵Diodoros, Book II.1.